

Dharmakīrti's Theory of Exclusion (*apoha*)

Part I

On Concealing

An Annotated Translation of *Pramāṇavārttikasvavṛtti* 24,16–45,20

(*Pramāṇavārttika* 1.40–91)

Vincent Eltschinger
John Taber
Michael Torsten Much
Isabelle Ratié

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Helmut Krasser
(1956–2014),
in memoriam

*Correspondence regarding all editorial matters should be sent to the Director of the
International Institute for Buddhist Studies in Tokyo.*

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Foreword

As Vincent Eltschinger, Helmut Krasser, and John Taber completed the English translation of *Pramāṇavārttikasvavṛtti* (PVSV) 164,24–176,16 in early August, 2008, questions quite naturally arose as to the best way to continue the fruitful collaboration begun in September, 2006. The group first thought of moving just one step back and translating PVSV 150,11–164,24, a passage linking up the so-called *vināśitvānumāna* to the concluding section that had just been dealt with. This was still part of Dharmakīrti's polemic against the Mīmāṃsā and contained a long excursus on mantras and their efficacy as well as a systematic exposition of Dharmakīrti's conception of phonemes (*varṇa*). However, the group's temptation to turn to the more ambitious task of translating the entire *apoha* section (PVSV 24,16–93,5) grew increasingly stronger. There could be no doubt about the importance of such a translation project. Much ink had been spilled over the *apoha* theory since Frauwallner's (1932, 1933a, 1935) groundbreaking German translation and study of *Pramāṇavārttika* (PV) 1.40–185 – arguably still the best introduction to Dharmakīrti's *apoha* – but none of the partial or complete translations published in the meantime rivaled that of the Viennese master. As *Can the Veda Speak?* was published in 2012, Eltschinger, Krasser, and Taber were convinced that the *apoha* option was both the most urgent and intellectually the most challenging. They asked Isabelle Ratié to join the translation group and decided to meet in the summer of 2013 or 2014 in Albuquerque, New Mexico, for a first reading session.

2012, however, turned out to be the year in which Helmut Krasser fell fatally ill – as many will remember, Helmut died in the early hours of 30 March, 2014. A few months earlier, he was still confident that he would recover and regarded the trip to Albuquerque as one of his dearest wishes. Be it just as a token of friendship and gratefulness to their deceased friend, Eltschinger, Ratié, and Taber decided not to give up the project and to honor his memory with a work worthy of his high scientific standards. Torsten Much, who had been working for years on a German translation of the entire *apoha* section, was invited to join the group, which was now scheduled to meet in the summer of 2015 in Vienna with the generous support of the Austrian Science Fund (FWF, thanks to our friend Horst Lasic, who had successfully taken over Helmut Krasser's FWF project). In December 2014, Taber applied for a translation grant from the National Endowment for the Humanities (NEH); he and Eltschinger prepared a sample translation of the initial part of the *apoha* section, PVSV 24,16–25,26. They decided to split this section into three parts of roughly similar length, each of which, they thought, would keep them busy for approximately three years. The first part would cover PVSV 24,16–45,20, and that is what is now being presented in this publication.

The new team met from July 9 to 31, 2015, at the Department of South Asian, Tibetan and Buddhist Studies of the University of Vienna (Taber and Eltschinger met a few more times in early August 2015 at the Institute for the Cultural and Intellectual History of Asia of the Austrian Academy of Sciences). Luo Hong (who at the time was affiliated with the China Tibetology Research Center in Beijing; he is currently Professor of Sanskrit and Buddhist Studies at Sichuan University) attended most of the meetings and made very valuable suggestions. During that period, they were able to translate PVSV

25,26–36,16. Towards the end of the Viennese session, Taber received word that the NEH application was successful. The project would thus be funded from January 1, 2016, to December 31, 2017, which would not only allow for a second reading session in the summer of 2016, but also for Taber to take leave from his teaching duties at the University of New Mexico in Spring, 2017, to complete the project – in Paris, where Isabelle Ratié and Eltschinger had relocated in September, 2014 and October, 2015, respectively, and not in Vienna, as was planned originally. And indeed, the team met from July 20 to August 10, 2016, in Albuquerque (in the Philosophy Department of the University of New Mexico) and Jemez Springs (Bodhi Manda Zen Center), where they translated PVSV 38,7–45,20. Some of these sessions were attended by Suguru Ishimura, a Ph.D. in philosophy from Hiroshima University who was visiting the University of New Mexico on a Bukkyo Dendo Kyokai scholarship. Less than one year later, Taber arrived in Paris (1 March, 2017), where he stayed until the end of August. During the six months he spent in France, he and Eltschinger met as often as possible to discuss various topics (especially relating to the scholarly apparatus accompanying the translation), even though other, much less interesting commitments hampered their wish to meet more often and to organize a semi-official reading seminar at the École Pratique des Hautes Études. Torsten Much and Isabelle Ratié joined the tandem in mid-July (9–20) for a third reading session devoted to working on PVSV 36,16–38,7, which had been left untranslated, and PVSV 24,16–25,26, the passage that was originally translated as the sample for the NEH proposal. Taber and Eltschinger met on a regular basis from August 5 to 17 to continue discussing the footnotes and Explanatory Notes.

The *modus operandi* of the team remained constant throughout the project: Eltschinger prepared a rough English translation of each passage; this translation was discussed word for word and modified until the agreement of all participants was reached – which more often than not took a few hours for a single sentence. They endeavored to reach a balance between elements often considered incompatible: philological accuracy, philosophical clarity, readability, and elegance. For each sentence, Eltschinger's provisional translation included, in footnotes, the entire Sanskrit and Tibetan texts of Śākyabud-dhi's and Kaṇvakagomin's commentaries; it was accompanied by text-critical remarks and an edition of the Tibetan version of the translated passage. This provided the *material prima* for the footnotes, which are but a selection of the most significant parts of these irreplaceable “indigenous” commentaries supplying introductory objections, word-for-word explanations, restatements and, in the case of Kaṇvakagomin, his own discussions intended to update and recontextualize Dharmakīrti's arguments. Taber compiled the synopsis and the Explanatory Notes. The technical nature of Dharmakīrti's arguments, which frequently allude to philosophical concepts and theories of other traditions, and the complexity of his interactions with Dignāga, Uddyotakara, and especially Kumābila, often called for the presentation of additional information of a historical and doctrinal nature that, it was felt, belonged most appropriately at the end of the translation. If most of the preparation work was carried out by Eltschinger and Taber (which explains why their names appear first in the authors' list), the whole group bears responsibility for the translation in its entirety.

This book is the first in a series planned to count three. We, the authors, have never felt we were saying the last word on this essential passage presenting what is arguably the core of Dharmakīrti's philosophy. Not only is it philosophically and philologically extremely difficult; it also had a complex reception in Buddhist as well as non-Buddhist India – not to speak of Tibet. As in the case of *Can the Veda Speak?*, a lot remains to be said about this passage, but we are proud to offer what we consider a readable translation of the text. A complete translation of the PVSV into Western languages can now be reasonably expected within the next ten years – the “logical” parts have been translated in German by Ernst Steinkellner (2013), the polemic against the *apauruṣeyatā* in French by Eltschinger (2007) and in English by Eltschinger, Krasser, and Taber (2012). Only the above-mentioned PVSV 150,11–164,24 might remain to be translated once the *apoha* section has been completed. It is our hope that this will serve as an incentive for others to translate in full the remaining chapters of Dharmakīrti's *Pramāṇavārttika*, not to speak of other works by the same philosopher. Can the works of such a decisive and generally well-researched philosopher reasonably remain *terrae incognitae* any longer? Paradoxically perhaps, the predominantly “philosophical” approach to Dharmakīrti's philosophy has been detrimental to its understanding by constantly focusing on the same few passages, disregarding how they relate organically to his system as a whole, and much too often neglecting philological and translation work.

We are pleased to express our heartfelt thanks to the Austrian Science Fund (project P27452–G15) for making our first meeting in Vienna possible, and to the National Endowment for the Humanities (project RQ–230552–15) for allowing the group to meet in New Mexico and John Taber to dedicate his time to this project during a six-month research leave in Paris. This book would never have seen the light of day without these two institutions' generous support, and we can only hope that it will give them good reason to continue to support us in the near future.

Thanks are also due to Horst Lasic for including work on this translation in the above-mentioned FWF research project, as well as Luo Hong and Suguru Ishimura for their valuable suggestions and warm company. Harunaga Isaacson deserves our heartfelt thanks for generously and almost instantly answering our questions.

This book would not be what it is without the support of Hosen Christiane Ranger, Abbess of Bodhi Manda Zen Center, the saloon Los Ojos, both in Jemez Springs, the Tractor Brewery in Albuquerque, and, last but not least, Hélène and Jean-Paul Ratié in Vannes, France.

Finally, we would like to express our gratitude to Akira Saito and initially Florin Deleanu for accepting this study for publication in their excellent series and making valuable suggestions.

Paris, August 2017